

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 09

The Demon's Softening

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 95 min read aloud
Scenes	17
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 09 — The Demon's Softening

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

Apollo reads the Dex as privilege. Athena sees Encore without seeing the tariff. Giovanni returns. At the hospital: Kuni without retaliation, Pryce, Eusine, then the admission — the softening was enough.

Place in the arc

Due: white hell; Dex; Encore; 37; the man in white.

Paid: Fire Fang / Roost; Glare replayed; monsters = holders; Giovanni seen; involuntary smile.

Open: Coyote; Johto / Kanto in Eusine; “her”.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Chris/Maria	Dex read; Dewgong; the ward
Apollo / Athena	Curiosity; ground for darkness
Giovanni	The predator's return
Kuni	Kimono Girl — retaliation optional
Pryce / Eusine	Ice; the fragile bond
Lance (Champion) / Lance (Rocket)	Ward visit · ワタル; stair witness
Green / Silver / Red	The bill; threshold; Mt. Silver silence
Lambda	Director's office — private delight

Places (EN anchors)

Johto (street, snow) · Radio Tower (summit, lower floor, director's office) · Goldenrod Municipal Hospital · near Mt. Silver · air over Goldenrod.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Encore / Glare	The iteration adds nothing to status. Dewgong is not absolved: the psychic tariff remains. Athena reads the move, not the cost.
Smog / figures	30 / 60 / 65: the Dex betrays Gold/Richter. Not a feat of memory.
Kuni	Hold the name from here if she is the same Kimono Girl.
Selective perception	Combat references: Alucard vs Egyptian vampires, EP01 So2 of Castlevania: Nocturne; Richter Belmont vs Drolta, EP08 So2.
P1 gels	hunting crop; imprecation; niveleur (absent here); Looong live... (absent here). Pokémon

	pronouns: it/its. Apollo: reverence, not merely respect.
Two Lances	Champion ワタル in the ward. Team Rocket executive on the stairs — witness only.

Screen durations (excluding titles)

Predator 40–50 s. Curiosity 3 min 30–4. Ground for darkness 4–5. Monsters 5–6. Gallantry 2 min 40–3. The bill 2 min 10–50. Retaliation 1 min 20–50. Wisdom of ice 2 min 20–3. Bond 4 min 20–5. Finitude 6 min 20–7.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
The Predator's Return	Annette's Journey	01:42–02:17
Soil for Darkness	Could Not Be Caged	00:30–end
The Truly Most Dangerous Monsters	Don't Listen to Her	01:04–02:04
The Truly Most Dangerous Monsters	Light in This Darkness	entry
Family Mourning	Little Boy Belmont	entry · 00:37– · 00:58– · 01:30– · 01:45– · 02:02–
Selective and Manipulable Perception	Your Choice	00:00 · 01:09 · 01:22 · 01:42 · 02:38 · 03:26
Johto's Rejection	Annette's Journey	00:52–01:14
Johto's Rejection / Mt. Silver	Black Eyes	01:35–
Johto's Rejection / Mt. Silver	Richter My Friend	00:37
The Coyote's Caustic Premium	Work of the Devil	entry · 00:20– · 01:11– · 01:39– · 01:52–
The Bill Settled	Somewhere Safe	00:59–end
The Fragile but Precious Bond	Making Monsters	00:00–00:44
The Fragile but Precious Bond	Don't Leave Me	01:27–end
The Finitude of Elevated Lucidity	You've Seen the Devil	entry
The Finitude of Elevated Lucidity	Lamento della Ninfa	entry · external

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
Scientific Curiosity	EP07 S01 13:43–16:00
Soil for Darkness	EP05 S01 14:09–14:46
The Truly Most Dangerous Monsters	EP05 S01 08:30–09:47
Gallantry Without Glory	EP05 S02 15:40–16:35
Gallantry Without Glory	EP05 S02 16:32–18:08 (+ 00:18– · 01:07– ·

	01:24–)
Who Is Behind You?	EP02 S01 22:40–24:14
Who Is Behind You?	EP01 S01 25:36–27:04
Victory Beyond Calculation	EP03 S01 16:54–17:29
Reciprocal Retaliation Is Optional	EP01 S02 08:00–08:16
The Aftermath of the Wisdom of Ice	EP02 S01 15:30–16:06
The Aftermath of the Wisdom of Ice	EP02 S02 15:20–16:20

Order of scenes

1. The Predator's Return
2. Scientific Curiosity
3. Soil for Darkness
4. The Truly Most Dangerous Monsters
5. Gallantry Without Glory
6. Family Mourning
7. Selective and Manipulable Perception
8. Johto's Rejection
9. Prestige Preserved
10. Who Is Behind You?
11. The Old Man Coyote's Caustic Premium
12. Victory Beyond Calculation
13. The Bill Settled
14. Reciprocal Retaliation Is Optional
15. The Aftermath of the Wisdom of Ice
16. The Fragile but Precious Bond
17. The Finitude of Elevated Lucidity

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

The Predator's Return

Somewhere in Johto

The snow was falling fine and thick, almost sticky. It was already piling up on the shoulders of passers-by, on the edges of shop signs, on turned-up collars.

The streets were less crowded than usual. Those still out and about moved with that particular weariness of days that drag on too long: the occupation of the Radio Tower, the cold, the conflicting announcements, the vague sense that something had already gone wrong somewhere.

A man was crossing the pavement from the opposite side. A dark coat, a steady gait, a figure who clearly did not belong in the area. A few glances fell upon him, but did not linger. Just long enough to note that he was not from here.

Then, for no apparent reason, he turned his head slightly.

BGM 'Annette's Journey' 01:42–02:17

His eyes lingered on the small group of passers-by. For just a fraction of a second. But time seemed to contract.

It wasn't anger. Nor was it curiosity. It was a quick, almost animal-like, assessing glance, taking in what lay before him... and immediately classifying it as insignificant.

He looked away as calmly as he had looked at them, and carried on his way.

No one spoke.

Yet something lingered. A low pressure, just below the throat, as if the air had grown slightly thicker. One of the men instinctively raised his hand to his collar. A woman slowed her pace without knowing why.

From a great distance, or perhaps from a poorly tuned radio in a shop that was still open, fragments of radio voices continued to drift by, distorted, almost unintelligible. Disjointed words. A rhythm that was too regular.

The man was already walking away, indifferent, gradually swallowed up by the snow and the half-light.

But behind him, on the pavement, the sensation lingered. Like the trace of a predator that had not even thought it worth staying.

End of scene

Scene – Scientific Curiosity : Apollo

Top of the Radio Tower

Snow clung to the large windows on the top floor. It had almost stopped falling, but the wind would occasionally press it against the glass, leaving irregular streaks. The air inside remained cold and dry, charged with a tension that was no longer confined to the battle alone.

Houndoom had not moved for several seconds. It crouched low, its muscles taut, its gaze fixed on Fearow with a patience that was far from that of an ordinary animal. Fearow, its wings half-spread, kept a scrupulous distance. It wasted nothing.

Gold/Richter spoke in as neutral a tone as he could manage.

‘Would I be too naive... to suggest that you’re calling Giovanni back to manipulate him from behind the scenes?’

Apollo did not reply straight away. He stood slightly apart, almost motionless, as if the weight of his own body required no effort at all. When he spoke, his voice remained even, almost polite.

“No. He deserves my reverence. Everyone is seasoned in their own field.”

He turned his head slightly towards Gold/Richter, just enough to show that he had perfectly grasped the intention behind the question.

“Are you betting on him being invincible...? Or on your organisation...”

Apollo tilted his chin ever so slightly:

“We need not be free from weaknesses. It is enough that we have fewer than average. And that we remain on the proper side ... so that our weaknesses prove more costly.”

Gold/Richter felt a tightening behind his ribs. He pressed on.

“Regardless of that... you aren’t absolutely loyal to him?”

“Lance, Athena and I... we respect him. We recognise his limitations. We don’t believe in paladins. Not even those of evil.”

The words fell flat. Gold/Richter looked away for a moment towards Fearow, as if to regain his footing.

Apollo continued, almost in a conversational tone:

“I’ve been looking into Master Giovanni’s activities... over the last few years. He’s certainly become more hardened. Or so they say.”

“Do you think he’ll accept your offer...?”

“In return, I am offering him some new strategies.”

Gold/Richter paused:

“Will he really go along with that...? He’s a warrior... not just some common villain.”

Apollo gave a very slight shrug.

“No doubt. We shall be able to reach some sort of compromise... or arrangement.”

Then, in a lower voice:

"You should know that I missed the chance to put him to the test more thoroughly... after refining my methods. That opportunity... will not slip through my fingers again."

Gold/Richter looked up.

"Is he merely a proband to you...?"

Apollo then looked at him properly:

"My intention... is to proceed in a more ethical manner."

The word hung in the air. Gold/Richter felt a wave of revulsion welling up too quickly. Apollo noticed this and added, coldly:

'For the great antagonists, certainly. Out of curiosity.'

"Is your motivation merely a matter of... so-called curiosity?"

Apollo tilted his head slightly.

BGM: "EP 07 S01 13:43–16:00"

"Curiosity and scientific humility are impulses... relatively healthy. Neutral. For self-improvement. To explore the outer circles... whilst sidestepping raw impulse. Much like science itself. I practise other scientific disciplines. Passionately. Like the scientists in our union. And like... figures such as Professor Oak."

The name fell without any particular weight. Yet something snapped inside Gold/Richter. A vague, misplaced rage.

Apollo realised this immediately.

"I can't think of a better example. Never mind."

It was not mockery; rather, it was the realisation that the comparison had gone beyond what a Pokédex holder could properly process at that moment.

Gold/Richter clenched his teeth.

"Science cannot be separated from scientific ethics..."

Apollo did not smile:

"I don't disagree. But the evidence speaks for itself. I'm more of a scientist... and a fatalist than a nihilist. If order cannot be established... within systems that are too antiquated, too corrupt... then certain norms — such as slavery — would become... inalienable. So that intrinsic savagery is not allowed to run completely rampant."

His voice remained matter-of-fact, almost sombre.

A sharp crack tore through the air.

Houndoom had moved.

It did not charge in a straight line. First it slid sideways, low to the ground, then propelled itself forward with an almost shocking economy of movement. Its fangs flared at the very last moment.

Fire Fang.

Fearow did not have time to get completely out of the way. The bared fangs sank into the flesh at the base of its left wing. A sharp crack, followed by a short, hoarse cry, which Fearow immediately stifled.

Gold/Richter took a step forward, his right arm tracing a sweeping, almost involuntary arc.

Fearow understood.

It spread its wings and activated Agility — but only for the duration of a single wingbeat, just enough to break its trajectory and reposition itself higher up, without exhausting itself. Then it dived towards a specific point on the ground, landed heavily, and, without even folding its wings completely, activated Roost.

The pale light of the healing move enveloped it.

Houndoom had already crouched, ready to give chase. Pursuit.

Fearow remained in Roost for another half-second — the maximum he could risk — then tore itself away from the ground without turning his body, just as Houndoom's fangs snapped shut on empty air.

It regained altitude, its left wing still trembling, but steady.

Gold/Richter exhaled a little of the breath he'd been holding.

Apollo had followed every movement with almost rapt attention. No despondency. Rather, a kind of focused interest.

He spoke again as if the battle had been nothing more than a brief interlude.

"By the way..."

He waited for Gold/Richter to look at him.

"Just as a reminder... Don't you find your claim... a bit strange? Smog... power 30...?"

Gold/Richter felt a sense of foreboding cross his mind. Still vague. But already chilling.

End of scene

Scene – Soil for Darkness Athena

Radio Tower

BGM 'Could Not Be Caged' 00:30–end

Snow was piling up against the narrow windows on the upper floor. It wasn't really falling any more; it clung, fine and heavy, transforming the light from outside into a white, dirty mist. The air inside remained cold, charged with a tension that had not yet found a way to release itself.

Arbok hadn't moved in a straight line. It had first moved sideways, low to the ground, almost skimming the floor, then fired a Poison Sting with clinical precision. Dewgong dodged it with a heavy but precise movement. A second sting followed immediately, not to hit, but to force it into a tighter corner.

Chris/Maria spotted the trap a fraction of a second too late.

Arbok lunged forward. Crunch.

The fangs closed around Dewgong's left shoulder with a dull, almost muted thud. Dewgong let out a hoarse gasp and, without waiting for a verbal command, fired Ice Shard. The shard of ice struck Arbok on the flank. Not hard enough to stop it, but enough to make it writhe and retreat in a sinuous, almost elegant movement.

At the same time, very low down, almost imperceptibly, Dewgong activated Aqua Ring. A thin ring of water began to circulate around its body, discreet, like a held breath.

Murkrow, perched higher up in the shadow of a beam, had not moved. It was simply watching.

Both Pokégear vibrated almost simultaneously.

Chris/Maria looked down, read Eusine's message quickly — short, urgent — then snapped the device shut. Athena did the same. Her expression darkened ever so slightly as she read Lance's note. She didn't change her expression, but something in her posture became more alert, more tense.

She looked up at Chris/Maria.

'If I may ask... what drives you to fight?'

Chris/Maria paid only half-hearted attention. Her fingers moved slightly along her thigh.

Athena continued, her voice steady:

"If fighting isn't really your speciality. And if you haven't... collected any badges."

"Why do we define ourselves by these... conventional criteria?"

Chris/Maria's reply was curt, a little too quick.

Athena tilted her head slightly.

'Not about that. I just find it hard to imagine a child deigning to... save their own country just to show off. Sounds more like a piece of fiction.'

Chris/Maria felt her fatigue and frustration rise a notch. Venomoth had already been lost through recklessness. She clenched her teeth for a moment.

"I'm not very good at it," said Chris/Maria. "But better than average. So... am I not worthy?"

Athena watched her for a moment.

"On the other hand. Your boldness is commendable. Even in agreeing to hold back your emotions... and your frustrations. With difficulty."

Chris/Maria exhaled a faint sigh:

"...All right. I'm a patriot. But not a show-off. A patriotic motive isn't enough to drive me. When it comes to you... I can't suppress my emotions. It falls to me to resign myself to them. Or to accept them. I'm acting because all this concerns those around me. A reason... that's been met."

She paused for a moment, then added more quietly:

"I'm not strong. But as someone who's privileged, I fulfil my duties. I won't leave our warrior alone. Not like... what they do in Kanto."

Athena gave a perfunctory smile, almost tactile, which committed her to nothing.

Chris/Maria did not pause.

“But why did you choose Johto... for your resurgence?”

Athena remained silent for a second too long. Something indescribable flashed behind her eyes.

“You could say... because Kanto has changed. Or perhaps not at all. It’s become almost stagnant, I think. A generational shift would be... helpful. Probably.”

“Are you expecting to recruit us...? Because of our status.”

“A valid reason. I’m not ignoring that. You’ll be able to contribute in an unconventional way. That’s... innovation.”

BGM “EP05 S01 14:09–14:46”

Chris/Maria held her gaze.

“Very well. But bear in mind that goodness needs fertile ground. So does evil. If evil didn’t survive in Kanto... its place of origin... it’s unlikely it’ll take root in Johto.”

She had spoken in an almost provocative tone, as if to channel a hint of resentment, but the conviction behind her words was genuine.

Athena seemed surprised for a moment. Not by brute force — there was none — but by this firmness detached from any superior power.

Then she offered a more sincere, almost cheerful smile. Chris/Maria, for her part, interpreted it as a form of underestimation of her naivety.

Athena continued, in a lower voice:

‘On my journey here... I had the impression that Johto wasn’t all that different from Kanto. But after a while... Johto often manages to never cease surprising me.’

She added, almost to herself:

“It really is a... very interesting region.”

Chris/Maria did not reply. She turned her attention back to Dewgong. Her fingers moved along her thigh, then through the air, in short, elegant, almost delicate gestures — barely visible to anyone who did not know how to look. Dewgong responded immediately, his gaze steady and focused.

Arbok opened its mouth and unleashed a Screech.

The shrill cry filled the floor. Dewgong shifted with a heavy movement to get out of the direct line of fire. Arbok swivelled its head with sudden speed and fired another Poison Sting. The needle merely grazed him, but the contact was enough to make Dewgong flinch.

Then Arbok crouched and unleashed Glare.

The snake’s eyes opened too wide, too fixed. Paralysis seized Dewgong in fits and starts. His body stiffened in places; his breathing grew shallower.

Yet, even as it slowed, Dewgong kept its eyes fixed on Chris/Maria’s fingers. Tiny, almost indecipherable movements continued to pass.

Arbok lunged forward to deliver a decisive blow.

To Athena's astonishment, it stopped dead in its tracks... then used *Glare* again.

The Glare was unleashed a second time, to no avail, upon a prey that had already been struck. Nothing changed in its status. The repetition had no tangible effect.

Dewgong, however, was not spared.

The second *Glare* did not intensify the paralysis. It merely **replayed** the first. The body recognised the gaze as too overwhelming even before the mind had time to classify it as futile. A shudder, more internal than physical. The terror had not been erased; it was no longer of use only to Arbok. Dewgong's eyes remained fixed on Chris/Maria's fingers — not because he was unscathed, but because the anchor held firm *despite* what had just returned.

Athena furrowed her brow ever so slightly. A few seconds passed.

'Is that... "Encore" ?'

She had understood the move, but not the cost.

Chris/Maria did not reply. She merely offered a brief, appropriate smile, then her fingers traced a wider, more fluid, almost lightning-fast movement through the air.

Dewgong, still partially paralysed, opened its jaws and unleashed Icy Wind at very close range.

The icy blast was not overwhelmingly powerful, yet at such close quarters the cold thickened at once, clinging to Arbok's scales, slowing its movements and instilling a bone-chilling numbness that spread throughout its body.

Arbok did not fall.

It remained there, slowed, the cold seeping between its plates, whilst the snow continued to fall silently against the windows.

End of scene

Scene – The Truly Most Dangerous Monsters

The Top of Radio Tower

Snow still clung to the large windows. It had almost stopped falling, but the wind would occasionally sweep it across the glass in irregular streaks, transforming the night outside into a dull, grimy surface. The air inside remained cold and dry, charged with a tension that had taken on a different quality.

BGM 'EP05 S01 08:30–09:47'

Houndoom had not moved for several seconds. It crouched low, motionless, its gaze fixed on Fearow with an age-old, almost ritualised patience. Fearow kept its distance, wings half-spread, without wasting a single wingbeat.

Gold/Richter's voice sounded harsher than he would have liked.

"What's that got to do with...?"

It wasn't really a question. More of a denial.

Apollo did not smile; he merely tilted his head ever so slightly.

"Mind your own words. Bite... Fire Fang... Smog. Power 60, 65... and 30."

Gold/Richter sensed something amiss.

"What... that's strange...?"

He was still trying to work it out. A sort of vocational amnesia was preventing him from grasping the essence of it straight away.

Apollo continued, his voice steady:

'...Why were you able to quote the figures... so precisely?'

His dismay mounted in an instant. A fragment of an answer had formed within him, too clear to be denied.

Apollo continued, without raising his voice:

"Most other trainers know... as a rule... only which ability is stronger. Or weaker. But only vaguely. How are you able... to quote the exact figures?"

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 01:04–02:04

Gold/Richter did not reply. An old guilt, long avoided, had just resurfaced.

Apollo continued, almost didactically, but in fragments:

'If you're accusing me of being part of the elite... the term "elite" refers to more accomplished Trainers. Like the Ace Trainers. They deserve that title... not solely because of their strongest Pokémon. But because they excel in superior knowledge. They possess advanced abilities and badges. They make use of the finest resources... such as TMs. According to these descriptions... that label does not apply to me.'

He paused for a moment.

"Your skill as a Trainer... is undeniable. But is it really just a feat on your part...? How did you come by... such pertinent information? What sets you apart from the others... is it really your exceptional talents? Or... could there be something else?"

The sentence made the hairs on the back of Gold/Richter's neck stand on end. He wanted to stop the reply. He was not given permission to do so.

Apollo concluded, without a trace of sarcasm:

"Is the answer not obvious? You possess a device... that the vast majority of people will never have. Knowledge... that only a privileged few can obtain."

Gold/Richter clenched his fists. His voice came out weaker than he would have liked:

“Are you referring... to the Pokédex?”

BGM ‘Light in This Darkness’

No sooner had he uttered the word than the weight of the object in the inside pocket of his tailcoat seemed to grow heavier. It was not quite real. Yet the burden had just made its presence felt.

Apollo tilted his head slightly. No sadism. No mockery. Rather, the nod of a pen-pusher confirming a file.

‘Precisely. You, the holders of the Pokédex... you monopolise the most precise data. The highest knowledge. So... if you accuse me of being part of the elite, I’ll turn the question back on you: who are the true elites... in your opinion? Are you not... the most privileged... and potentially... the most dangerous monsters?’

His tone was not unyielding; it even contained a kind of cynical compassion, as if he were weighing the gravity of what he had just said.

Gold/Richter spoke with difficulty:

“But... it remains a tool. Science is neutral in itself... It is will that dictates...”

“It’s more than that.”

“How...?”

Apollo shifted his weight ever so slightly. The movement was almost ghostly.

“An ordinary trainer... would be virtually inconsequential to the veterans. Even if they had a Pokédex. The stark difference... is that you are the professors’ favourites.”

Gold/Richter’s inner apprehension reached an unprecedented peak. He remained standing, still capable of bravery, but no longer able to shield himself from the frustration gnawing at him.

Apollo continued, in a low voice:

“Pokédexes are merely the surface. The trappings. The emblems. They symbolise your access... to research, to data, to mentoring... all of which is almost exclusive. Forbidden to others. Pokédexes... they are the symbols of your privilege. They allow you to win badges, to command powerful Pokémon, including wild ones. My minions can control these urban pests, to a relatively limited extent, but no further, for lack of badges... And you are... the true elite.”

Gold/Richter felt as though he were committing an abomination. Not against Apollo. Against himself.

Apollo added, almost in passing:

“The boy with the red hair... he had a very rare Pokémon. Stolen from the professor, I presume. But he couldn’t stop us. Because he lacked... a structured education... high-quality information. Nor can he defeat you... plausibly.”

Gold/Richter stammered. Apollo noted his despondency without deriving any satisfaction from it.

“I’m not really blaming you. I’m not trying to justify myself. I’m simply reminding you... of what you’ve always preferred not to face up to.”

He paused.

"Let us simply say that pre-excellence and power... are the source of corruption. Just as Master Giovanni's badge... allows him to command any Pokémon to obey him."

"I am... constantly aware of that. I... I always strive to prevent such tragedies."

Apollo tilted his head slightly.

"That is certainly true. But does that exempt you... from the burden?"

Gold/Richter could not refute the assertion. He merely maintained a fierce reserve.

Apollo continued, in a lower voice, with an almost cruel empathy:

'Yes... like a little gadget. It's heavy. Too heavy.'

Apollo continued:

'If this version is true... Red stood up to his rival at the League... simply because that lad was blinded by his status... and his inherent privilege. How melancholy. But you must know more about it than I do.'

The mention of Red stirred up a rawer passion. Apollo watched him out of the corner of his eye.

"I discovered my methods... whilst observing Red. But even he... he was defeated."

'Are you... are you mocking him...?'

"No. As long as my plan remained unclear... my decision depended on its outcome. He failed. I can't help but feel a touch of sympathy."

"As if you could possibly understand him..."

Gold/Richter's inner fury was spreading, on the verge of breaking free.

Apollo continued, his voice almost gentle:

"We projected sanitised expectations onto a teenager. Friendship. Bonding. Fulfilment... solely to satisfy the collective complacency of adults. We ruined his life. But in fact... we needed him. Just as the henchmen need Master Giovanni. A cruelty of the masses."

Gold/Richter spoke with forced sarcasm:

"As if you'd done all this... to avenge him..."

The anger evaporated unexpectedly. Almost nothing remained of it.

Apollo shook his head ever so slightly.

"Not at all. These are the consequences. Once you attain such clarity... you cannot escape this sort of realisation."

Suddenly, Apollo heard barely audible drops.

His attention shifted to Gold/Richter's face.

Tears had just begun to stream down, calmly, without a sob.

Gold/Richter only realised this in hindsight. He didn't know why they were flowing. He brushed a tear with the tip of his index finger, as if to confirm it.

He hadn't been mistaken.

His voice came out almost in disbelief:

'Are these... my tears...?'

End of scene

Scene — Gallantry Without Glory — Athena

Radio Tower

BGM "EP05 S02 15:40–16:35"

Snow was barely drifting through the tall windows. The air was heavy, laden with a cold dampness that clung to the skin.

Murkrow flapped its wings once, slowly. On either side of its body, a black mist escaped gently, almost languidly. It thickened, creeping along the edges of the pillars, absorbing the faint light. An ancient, familiar sensation rose in Chris/Maria's throat: that of being watched from within the mist.

Athena remained motionless. Her gaze was fixed on the space in front of her, yet she also seemed to be listening further away, higher up, as if something else might suddenly appear.

Chris/Maria felt the weight building up behind her eyes. Venomoth. Recklessness. Then what followed, all too quickly. Her fingers were cold. Dewgong, still on the ground, was breathing with an artificial regularity that Aqua Ring was barely managing to sustain. The residual paralysis from Glare made every movement a struggle.

Murkrow tilted its head. Night Shade was unleashed without a cry. A blade of shadow cut through the mist and pierced Dewgong right through. The creature shuddered, but held firm.

Chris/Maria raised her hand. Her fingers arranged themselves with a ghostly, almost surgical precision. Ice Shard shot forth.

The projectile's trajectory broke midway. The paralysis had slowed its launch by a fraction of a second too long. Murkrow stepped aside with a single flap of its wings, unhurriedly, as if it had not needed to exert any more force.

Chris/Maria closed her eyes. For a second. No more. She opened them again. The calculation was done.

She recalled Dewgong. The light from the Poké Ball wrapped itself around its body, still reeling from Night Shade. Murkrow made a sharp, purposeful wing movement — Pursuit — but it was too late. Dewgong's silhouette had already vanished.

Chris/Maria gripped the Ball with three fingers, drew another from their pouch, and hurled it. Not too near. Not too far. A deliberately ambiguous distance.

Haunter emerged.

BGM 'EP05 S02 16:32–18:08'

Athena and Murkrow reacted at the same time. It wasn't fear. It was the instant recognition of an intention: Curse. The potential sacrifice. Murkrow dived immediately, wings clamped tight, trajectory clear. His movements signalled Pursuit. He wanted to strike before Haunter's shadow took hold.

That was when Eusine acted.

BGM "EP05 S02 16:32–18:08" 00:18–

His Poké Ball traced a short arc. Barely released, Electrode was already rolling. Rollout. The yellow body struck Murkrow at an angle, deep within the mist. The impact was muffled, violent, unexpected. Murkrow was thrown off course, disoriented.

Electrode vanished into the darkness once more. All that could be heard was the rumbling – irregular and difficult to pinpoint.

Eusine was already moving towards Chris/Maria.

Electrode reappeared. It had found its target by instinct. The second collision was more direct. A clean hit.

Murkrow shuddered mid-flight. Its wings lost their fluidity. It tried to regain altitude, but every flap now required visible effort, as if the air had become denser around it.

For the first time, Athena showed clear signs of tension. She had understood.

BGM "EP05 S02 16:32–18:08" 01:07–

"Static's paralysis..." she murmured.

Eusine drew level with Chris and Maria. He gave only the faintest of smiles.

"Fortunately, my attempt has paid off."

He looked at her. His voice remained low, almost dry:

"You've fought bravely. Now, leave the rest to the adults."

BGM 'EP05 S02 16:32–18:08' 01:24–

Chris/Maria did not reply. She felt relief, but it erased nothing. Her eyes were dry, devoid of any sparkle. The fatigue she had been holding in since the start of the battle no longer needed to be concealed. She did not recall Haunter. The Pokémon remained suspended in mid-air, motionless, like a last resort that, in the end, had not needed to be used.

Murkrow was still hovering in the air. Its wings flapped with a forced regularity. Athena stood motionless.

From the lower flight of stairs, Lance (Team Rocket) had approached at the very moment Eusine had thrown his Poké Ball. He stopped halfway up the stairs, one hand on the banister, and watched the end unfold without making a single move. He hadn't come to intervene. He'd simply come so as not to miss the conclusion.

End of scene

Scene — Family Mourning

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont'

The snow had almost stopped falling. It hung suspended in the cold air, as if hesitating.

Gold/Richter looked at his hand. A drop had formed on his index finger. It had not fallen yet. It remained there, trembling, as if it did not quite belong to this body.

He was not accustomed to weeping before an enemy.

Fearow sensed it immediately. Its feathers bristled. The bird turned its head slightly towards its trainer, then towards Houndoom. Houndoom, for its part, did not move. It watched from the corner of its eye, its nostrils slightly flared. It was reading something. Not pity. A variation. A flaw.

Gold/Richter spoke without really raising his voice.

“Why can’t I control them any more... My emotions...”

A tear finally rolled down. Then another. Then more.

He found himself half-kneeling without having decided to do so. The tears were already soaking the ground.

“I knew that Pokédex holders could become monsters. I accepted this burden so that others wouldn’t abuse it. Not to play the hero.”

His voice broke in places, without any pretence. Just the exhaustion of someone who’d held on for too long.

Apollo did not reply. He remained perfectly still. Too still. For the first time in a long while, something was slipping past him. He had seen men beg, threaten, justify themselves, hate. He had almost never seen anyone break down under the sheer weight of a sincere admission, without accusation, without demand.

Houndoom took a step forward. Fearow, affected by its trainer’s state, had lowered its guard ever so slightly. Bite.

The fangs found their mark. Not enough to kill. Enough to make him stagger.

Gold/Richter didn’t even lift his head straight away.

“Why can a demon... express Red’s pain better than those who loved him... better than me, sometimes...”

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont' 00:37–

Apollo looked away slightly. A minimal, almost elegant movement, as if he were slipping out of his usual posture. He did not know what to make of this scene.

He held up two fingers. Houndoom understood. Smog spread out, wider, denser, a greyish-yellow mist that swallowed the space between them.

Fearow reacted out of instinct. Roost. It folded its wings, forcing itself to recover. The poison was already taking hold. For a fighting Pokémon, it was a slow, methodical humiliation.

Gold/Richter's tears were no longer mere drops. They streamed in continuous lines down his cheeks, leaving glistening trails that almost froze in the cold.

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont' 00:58–

He murmured, even more quietly:

'I'm sorry... Chris/Maria. For hurting you. For nothing.'

Images flashed back in no particular order. The Ecruteak Festival. Her protective sarcasm. The way she'd agreed to go to Krise. The tenderness he'd let slip by, and the tenderness she'd almost returned to him.

"I don't really understand... why you can still forgive an idiot like me."

The faces of Morty, Karin, the Kimono Girls, Oak, Fuji, Eusine, Mike, Krise, Bryan. All those sincere people. And him, here, on his knees, losing.

"What would you do in my place, Red...?"

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont' 01:30–

He was not really expecting an answer. He simply had no one else left to ask.

So Lance's words (the Champion Wataru, not the Team Rocket executive Lance) came back to him. Not as a conscious memory. More like something that had been waiting.

"Red's flame did not arise of its own accord. It was... tempered. As if something deeper had soothed it. Without that, it would have consumed everything. Red forged it through his choices."

Gold/Richter remained silent.

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont' 01:45–

A wave washed over his chest. Not a clear vision. The heat of a flame. A surge of water. A dragon-like sensation. Blurred silhouettes: Misty, both younger and older at the same time. Red. Lance.

Then what followed, even deeper in his memory:

"I wasn't entirely to blame, nor was my leadership. The institution isn't bad in itself. It simply needs to be humanised. Like that flame."

BGM 'Little Boy Belmont' 02:02–

He blinked.

Why had he been so blind?

He propped himself up on one knee, then slowly sat up. The tear streaks were still there, glistening, frozen by the cold. But no new ones were coming.

In the Smog, he could hardly see a thing. He simply looked at his own open palms.

When his voice returned, it was hoarse but steady.

'I'm not entirely to blame either. My approach isn't entirely in vain.

I still have some cards up my sleeve."

End of scene

Scene – Selective and Manipulable Perception

Top of Radio Tower

The continuation of the fight against Apollo

BGM « Your Choice » – 00:00

The wind whistled faintly through the broken windows. Snow was falling outside, but the upper floor remained dark, lit only by the moon.

Gold/Richter sat up slowly. His eyes were still wet, but he had already stopped crying. He wiped his face one last time with the back of his hand, in a sudden, almost shameful gesture. He no longer wanted to show this weakness.

Apollo watched him in silence. He had not moved since the tears had started to flow. Something about that raw emotion had made him feel uneasy. He was not used to seeing an opponent in that state.

Gold/Richter remarked, in a low, slightly hoarse voice:

‘...That doesn’t make sense.’

He looked up at Apollo. His gaze was different now — darker, more tense.

“The same ploy. Haze is used to recall. Why is it that even the god of death failed several times to drive out the humans... yet the guardian of hell succeeded just once? Pursuit during the recall is not part of wild behaviour, but synthetic...”

He clenched his teeth.

“Because you’re no amateur. But if this Houndoom’s savagery is genuine... then it can be channelled. Not always controlled.”

Apollo did not reply. He continued to watch Gold/Richter, a slight tension visible on his face.

“Well then,” said Gold/Richter, “it is time for me to make use of that savagery... and pay the heavy price...”

“Your Choice” – 01:09

Gold/Richter recalled Fearow with a sharp gesture.

There was no command. No visible strategy. He simply stepped forward, then slid sideways, the hunting crop already hanging loosely by his side.

Houndoom reacted even before Apollo could speak. A much denser, almost black Smog exploded in front of him and engulfed the space in a second.

Gold/Richter vanished into it.

Apollo barely furrowed his brow; this time, the boy had not thought it through.

'Your Choice' – 01:22

Inside, there were no longer any contours. Only the chemical burn in his throat, Houndoom's low growl, and the memory of the ground.

Gold/Richter stepped forward without trying to see, trusting where the beast had been a second earlier, the stir of air, the scrape of claws on concrete.

He emerged from the heart of the Smog as one emerges from water. The hunting crop traced a short, low, vicious arc. The impact was a dull thud. Flesh and muscle.

Houndoom took a startled step back and finished its Smog at an angle, the cloud becoming uneven.

The beast charged immediately. In the fog its attacks lost their precision. Gold/Richter, for his part, seemed to have already adapted to the blindness. He didn't dodge widely. He slid, ducked, let the fangs pass a few centimetres away, and struck back — short, repeated, without elegance.

Several blows landed before the Smog began to clear.

The final blow sent out a louder, more resonant rustle of the whip's leather.

'Your Choice' – 01:42

The Smog gradually cleared.

Gold/Richter and the Houndoom stood facing each other. Gold/Richter was already breathing more heavily. A gash ran across his left cheek, and blood was trickling down to his chin. His coat was torn at the right shoulder, where the Houndoom's fangs had clamped down on it. He wiped the blood away with the back of his hand, without taking his eyes off the Pokémon.

Apollo had taken a step forward, but stopped. He realised that his Houndoom had been provoked. Intervening now risked shattering what remained of its instinct.

'Your Choice' – 02:38

The fight grew more brutal and more intense.

Gold/Richter was no longer fighting from a distance. Every time the Houndoom lunged at him, he struck back with the hunting crop, but also with the handle and the knob when the animal got too close. The blows were short, hard, almost desperate.

The Houndoom bit several times. Each bite was deep, intrusive, almost intimate — as if the fangs sought not only to wound, but to **lock on**. Houndoom did not growl. It held its grip, its body pressed against Gold/Richter's, like an ancient creature refusing to release the throat it had chosen. The effect of Flinch was not merely a shock: it was a moment of forced submission, in which Gold/Richter found himself immobilised in a closeness he had never learnt to handle.

Gold/Richter took the blows. He was no longer trying to remain composed. He struck out, retreated, struck out again. Blood ran down his arm and stained the leather of the handle. His breathing was ragged.

Then, with a sharp, precise movement, the Houndoom struck the hunting crop with its head. The crop flew several metres away, out of immediate reach but still within striking distance — a distance just critical enough to force Gold/Richter to choose between retrieving it or continuing to defend himself.

Gold/Richter, without hesitation, drew his cane in one fluid motion. The cane came down on the Houndoom's muzzle with a sharp crack. The Pokémon took half a step back, more startled than injured. Gold/Richter seized the opportunity to strike again, but the Houndoom tensed its entire body and delivered a headbutt straight on, horns first.

The impact was brutal. Gold/Richter's head was split open at the temple and forehead. Blood spurted out immediately—warm, sticky—running into his left eye. The pain exploded, white and blinding. Gold/Richter staggered, but did not fall.

The Houndoom gave him no time to catch his breath. It charged again, seeking to lock horns with him once more.

Gold/Richter staggered backwards, his cane raised to parry. Blood was now running down his temple and neck. He could feel his vision blurring at times. But he didn't let up.

Then, in an almost desperate move, he lunged forward and struck the Houndoom squarely in the forehead with his own head. The impact reverberated through his entire skull. The Houndoom staggered back, taken by surprise. Gold/Richter seized the opportunity to rush towards the hunting crop that had fallen earlier. His fingers closed around the leather just as the Houndoom charged once more.

He spun round and wrapped the crop around the Houndoom's neck with a sharp, violent motion. Then he pulled with all his might whilst striking the Pokémon's head with the metal part of the handle, again and again, until the Houndoom's eyes rolled back and its body collapsed, unconscious. It was as if Gold/Richter's eyes were ablaze with blue flame.

'Your Choice' – 03:26

Gold/Richter remained standing, swaying slightly. Blood was trickling down his temple, his forehead and his side. He was breathing with difficulty. The wound on his forehead continued to bleed profusely; it wasn't life-threatening, but enough for the blood to run into his eye and down his jaw.

He leaned against a pillar, one hand pressed against his wounded side. His hunting crop hung limply in his other hand. He looked exhausted and hollow.

Apollo did not move straight away. He kept a cautious distance. He had clearly seen Gold/Richter's physical condition, but he did not yet know whether he was fully in control:

'I nearly fell for it myself... It's easy to overlook. Genuine savagery, but directed. Whilst you were thrown off balance, your Houndoom lost its bearings. It wasn't really obeying you any more.'

He paused to catch his breath, then continued:

"...I almost forgot one thing. Advanced abilities... require greater precision. Greater control. But the simplest ones... the most instinctive... they're quicker. More reliable. More versatile for different circumstances and environments... A predator doesn't need to think too much before it bites. It just does it."

He looked up slightly at Apollo:

"That is why you rely on fundamental moves, is it not? Because they are swift. Because they do not demand complex coordination. Your method... lets you remain unobserved. A well-executed sleight of hand. A new breed of elite."

He wiped the corner of his mouth with the back of his hand, leaving a trace of blood on his skin.

"You told me that Pokédex holders were the most dangerous," said Gold/Richter.

"But you... you don't just exploit them by force. You use the savagery of your Pokémon, whilst staying out of the way. To evade the consequences of the seven deadly sins, rigidity..."

He spat a little blood to one side.

"So tell me... Who are really the most dangerous? Those who get their hands dirty... or those who make others do the dirty work?"

Apollo remained silent for a long moment. His expression was hard to read. Finally, a faint, cold smile appeared:

"...You are simply to be commended for repeating my questions."

End of scene

Scene — Johto's Rejection

Top of Radio Tower *A snowy evening. Immediately after Houndoom's fall*

Gold/Richter drew in short, gasping bursts; with every breath his chest rose a little too high, as if the air struggled to force its way through. Injuries tugged at the skin beneath his clothes. He remained leaning forward for a moment, his hands on his knees, before straightening his upper body with calculated slowness.

When his voice finally emerged, it no longer had the steadiness it had possessed before the battle. He was straining to make it louder.

'And you... are worthy of my praise. A true master... of sleight of hand.

You are not merely a manipulator of Pokémon. Nor of humans. You also excel... at manipulating false perceptions. Deep-rooted fallacies. Collective illusions."

He paused for a longer breath. The conviction he was maintaining was forced, held back from collapsing.

Apollo barely moved. Only a very slight tilt of the head, as if he were slipping within his own stillness.

"What a speech... riding the updraft."

BGM: 'Annette's Journey' 00:52–01:14

Gold/Richter drew a Ball from his belt. He did not throw it. He merely held it aloft, at chest height.

"I haven't truly transcended you. But my skill... was enough to subdue you.

Johto rejects the archaic order you invoke. And slavery... as ever."

He drew a breath. The next sentence cost him more effort.

"By all accounts... you've only got Koffing left, and it's in top form. It wouldn't stand a chance... against my Alakazam.

So. Do you insist on continuing... or do you surrender?"

Apollo let a second pass. His irony, when it came, was muted, almost weary.

“Is this an offer... or blackmail, in practice?”

He did not really expect an answer. He made a slight, elegant gesture with his hand.

“Very well. Let us spare ourselves the rest. I accept your proposal.”

Houndoom, still on the ground, was recalled. The light from the Ball wrapped itself around him unhurriedly. Apollo caught the object in mid-air, holding it with just three fingers, as one picks up something one has never really lost.

From inside his suit, he produced a small case. His thumb brushed a button.

The broadcast cut out.

Near Mt Silver

BGM: ‘Black Eyes’ — 01:35–

The shelter smelled of damp wood and the emergency heater. Apollo’s voice had been filling the room for several minutes already. Red listened to him without moving, his gaze fixed somewhere between the floor and the wall.

That voice calmed him. A fearful sense of abashment washed over him, familiar and ancient.

Then silence fell all at once.

Red looked up. Surprised. As if something lethal had just been removed without warning.

In the sky, Goldenrod was visible

Green was flying amidst a light snowfall, with Pidgeot hovering steadily beneath him. He’d switched on the programme earlier, the volume low, almost as a matter of habit. He wasn’t really listening to it. He was just checking.

When the broadcast cut out, he showed no surprise. Just a sharper focus, a slight adjustment to his posture.

He continued to fly.

Further out into the night

Lance, riding Dragonite, was crossing landscapes already shrouded in darkness. The broadcast cut out.

His demeanour remained almost unchanged. But something stirred in his subtle gestures: a question, held back, unspoken.

Near Mt Silver *BGM:*

'Richter My Friend' — 00:37

Red remained seated in the sudden silence. He found it hard to believe.

He had been spared the trouble of making his way over to Team Rocket. Someone had cut off the broadcast. Someone had nullified, or at least halted, whatever was still speaking in his place.

But who?

The screen faded to black, leaving him with a host of questions he did not yet know how to ask.

End of scene

Scene — Prestige Preserved

Radio Tower. *Immediately after the broadcast went off the air.*

Top floor

Apollo said nothing. He took a device from the inside pocket of his suit — an old, compact model with sharp contours. His fingers moved with an almost ghostly agility, as if they were gliding over the surface of the object rather than touching it.

A brief message. Send.

He put the device away without a second glance.

Lower Level

The residual Smog had cleared. Haunter and Vileplume remained facing each other, almost motionless, like two pieces that had been forgotten on the chessboard.

Beneath her calm exterior, Athena still carried the vague tension of a mounting disadvantage. She didn't let it show.

The phone vibrated against her hip. A silent tremor.

A few metres away, the same signal reached Lance.

They read the messages.

No comment. Just a shared, cold, pragmatic composure.

The Director's Office

Lambda started slightly at the rustle of the phone. He was half slumped in the armchair.

He read it.

A fleeting look of initial disappointment flitted across his face. Then something else took its place — a mischievous, narrow, almost private delight. He remained motionless for a moment, his gaze fixed on the screen.

Lower Floor

Athena raised her hand. Vileplume was recalled with unemotional ease. She caught the Ball in mid-air in a single fluid motion.

Eusine registered the movement. Chris/Maria, for her part, barely noticed it. Her moral weariness still numbed her too much for her to enjoy the spectacle, or even to really take notice of it.

Athena turned her head slightly towards them. Her smile was almost serene, almost natural.

‘Victory is yours this time.’

The sentence came without provocation. Nor was it a pretence.

The interruption suited her. She no longer had to see the defeat through to the end, nor to capitulate outright. The pretext was legitimate, pragmatic, and sufficient to preserve what needed to be preserved.

She put the Ball away. The fight below died down without further ado.

End of scene

Scene — Who Is Behind You?

Radio Tower, top floor. A snowy evening. Immediately after the broadcast was cut off.

Apollo stood motionless for a moment. Then he tilted his head slightly, as if accepting a formality that had already been settled.

BGM ‘EP02 S01 22:40–24:14’

“...So be it. I admit defeat.

Giovanni did not come. And I have no intention of wasting any more resources on a cause already lost.

I hereby formalise the dissolution of Team Rocket in this region.”

He accompanied his words with a ceremonial, almost nonchalant gesture — one hand opening, then closing, as if putting a file away.

“Satisfied?”

Gold/Richter was still breathing in short, uneven gasps. The question came out more hoarse than he would have liked.

“Why such composure... if your plan has gone awry?”

Apollo did not really smile; just a slight shift of his eyes.

“Master Giovanni once acknowledged his downfall... and Team Rocket’s rise. I am following that code of conduct. For having borrowed his instinct. Otherwise, it would have been chaos.”

He paused very briefly:

"Moreover... my downfall could lead to your stagnation. Your rigidity. If you were to limit yourselves to that... and lower your guard.

Not everything is entirely lost."

Gold/Richter felt the words sink in, unprompted, simply lucid. A slight sense of discouragement washed over him.

Apollo continued, still in the same tone:

"An elite of evil, such as myself, is part of the minority. But it is replaceable. I have no shortage of successors. My outcome will serve as... valuable data for them."

Gold/Richter looked up.

"I can hardly understand... I have seen through your sleight of hand... and yet you stand there, almost indifferent. It is... inhuman."

Apollo let a second pass. Then a faint, cold, clinical smile.

"Indeed. I have already experienced the humiliation of being outdone by a teenager."

'But a question crossed my mind.'

"What was it?"

Apollo regarded him with an almost detached curiosity.

"To manage to see through my schemes... what price did a boy of your age really have to pay?

It is far more disheartening... than simply being outdone."

Gold/Richter did not reply.

Apollo's gaze then slid, sharp, downwards. Towards the spot where the fabric of the outfit was torn, stained, and open just enough to reveal muscle and wounds.

He said nothing more. He didn't need to.

Gold/Richter followed that gaze in spite of himself. A sense of unease welled up within him, but exhaustion prevented him from showing it. He was too weary.

Apollo continued, almost to himself:

'It seems... it wasn't just me who underestimated your ability. You underestimated yourself, too.'

BGM "EP01 S01 25:36-27:04"

A longer silence settled over them.

Gold/Richter finally spoke, his voice lower and more broken.

"You are constantly... both so cold and so clear-headed. What exactly have you been through?"

"I'm reluctant to talk about my past. It would be too ostentatious."

'That doesn't add up...'

Apollo turned his head slightly.

“Hm...?”

Gold/Richter searched for the right words. They would not come easily.

“I was expecting... an antagonist full of lies. Or grandiloquence.

But you... you have only spoken the truth. Even if it is selective. Even if it is cynical.

The savagery you have tamed... is genuine.

So your compassion... cannot be entirely feigned.

But... it's biased, isn't it? It's of no use to evil.

Otherwise... you wouldn't have been affected by my excessive frustration. And I wouldn't have... won.”

He paused. He was out of breath.

‘Exclusively... are some of your prodigies... directed towards someone specific...?’

Not the rest.

Are you... truly yourself...?”

Apollo stared at him for a long moment. His expression hardly changed:

‘...What are you talking about?’

The question hung in the cold air of the uppermost floor.

End of scene

Scene — The Old Man Coyote's Caustic Premium

Radio Tower, top floor

Gold/Richter was no longer looking at Apollo. His gaze had shifted behind him, fixed on a point that the cold air seemed to thicken.

‘...Who's behind you, over there...?’ said Gold/Richter.

Apollo turned his head with an almost elegant slowness.

“There's no one there.”

“But there is...”

The silence stretched on.

Then something began to take shape.

First, a sense of scale. A height. A stature too vast for an ordinary body.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil'

Then a silhouette gradually took shape, like a black mist that refused to dissipate. The full features of the face were not yet discernible, but the outline was already there: human from certain angles, and yet distinctly other. Supernatural, ancient, standing in the moonlit gloom.

The expression then took on substance. A smile. Sinister. Intrusive. Not a mocking smile. A smile that seemed to have been there since the beginning of the world, and which was lying in wait for them.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil' 00:20–

Gold/Richter spoke in a low voice, as if under duress:

'An old man in black... behind you. Or rather... a black mist.

His smile is so... sinister. Intrusive.

He's watching us. Constantly.

His face... macabre. Spectral."

Apollo stood motionless for a second too long:

'...Is this a hallucination? I hope you're affected by my Houndoom's Smog.'

Yet the smile itself had become almost audible. Oppressive. Intriguing. Ritualistic. It was no longer content merely to watch. It lingered.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil' 01:11–

Outside, a Murkrow flew past the window. Its flight slowed suddenly, almost imperceptibly, as if it were aligning itself with something. As if it were saluting.

Gold/Richter realised then, too weary to bear the full weight of it: these Murkrow were not truly obeying Team Rocket. The ghost was their master.

The realisation struck him. A bitter price to pay for having exposed one too many deceptions.

'It was him... who manipulated you, wasn't it?

It wasn't really you... that I was fighting."

Apollo turned his face away slightly:

'...Please, stop deluding yourself.'

His voice had lost some of its ease. Even he was no longer entirely immune.

Footsteps echoed in the stairwell. Eusine appeared first, matching her pace to that of Chris/Maria, who was climbing more slowly, still visibly shaken.

Gold/Richter turned his gaze towards her. A faint flicker of relief crossed his eyes.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil' 01:39–

Chris/Maria, for her part, saw only the injuries at first. The torn clothes, the blood, the exhaustion. A vague, existential pain rose in her throat, barely bearable. She said nothing.

Apollo watched them for a moment from the shadows. Something had already taken root within him—a preliminary assumption about the young man.

He took out a Ball.

'Do you mean to flee?' said Eusine.

Then, in a lower voice, to Eusine:

"You nearly brought Master Giovanni to justice, years ago. And now... you're putting us under arrest?" asked Apollo.

Eusine ignored the insult:

"What a load of bombast."

Apollo twirled the Ball lightly between his fingers.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil' 01:52-

"This Koffing is powerful enough to use Explosion.

I've conceded defeat. But that doesn't rule out... the possibility that I've made other arrangements."

Eusine understood the warning and chose not to press the matter further.

Apollo turned his attention back to Gold/Richter:

'And you're in no condition to deal with me. This young master needs medical attention.

Otherwise... do you expect me to administer the antidote to him myself?"

The sarcasm was chilling, pragmatic. He was not even really trying to take pleasure in the remark any more. He was simply using it.

He put the Ball away.

"Very well, young man.

Always look... where the darkness hides best.

You might convert me, perhaps. Despite my neutrality... I'd look forward to seeing how you perform in the future."

Gold/Richter's gaze had already faded; he no longer had the strength to reply.

Apollo nodded slightly:

'Take care of yourself.'

The tone was almost benevolent. More so than before. And for that reason, all the more insidious.

He walked away.

Gold/Richter felt his knees give way. He slumped to the ground before he had even seen him leave.

The screen grew dark as his eyes closed.

End of **BGM: 'Work of the Devil'**

End of scene

Scene — Victory Beyond Calculation

Goldenrod City Municipal Hospital

The room was bathed in late-afternoon light, too harsh, almost white. The walls, painted in a shade somewhere between cream and grey, absorbed the daylight without lending it any warmth. A faint smell of disinfectant still lingered, mingled with the more neutral scent of freshly changed sheets. From a distance, in the corridor, steady, muffled footsteps could be heard.

Gold/Richter was half-seated against the pillows. The patient's gown, too loose at the shoulders, slipped slightly to one side, revealing the understated line of his pectoral muscles and the tops of his collarbones. Nothing ostentatious. Just the clear trace of what he'd had to maintain to keep going. The clothes he'd worn before being admitted were no longer there; Houndoom had rendered them unusable.

He wasn't looking at Lance.

His eyes remained fixed on a specific point, slightly to the left of the window, where the light met the shadow cast by the sill. He was listening. But his attention seemed drawn elsewhere, as if he had to maintain a distance to prevent himself from breaking down completely.

Lance was sitting on the chair by the bed, his back straight, his hands resting on his knees. He observed Gold/Richter's demeanour without impatience. His downcast gaze, his slightly laboured breathing, the way the teenager's fingers would occasionally clench the sheet. He held no blame against him.

The silence lingered.

Then Lance spoke, in a low, almost matter-of-fact voice.

BGM: 'EP03 S01 16:54–17:29'

"Luckily, you got there before us..."

Gold/Richter didn't need to ask who the 'us' referred to. He replied after a short pause, without taking his eyes off his fixed point:

"...My victory isn't quite as it should be. Nothing to make a fuss about."

Lance tilted his head slightly.

"You're wrong. It was precisely your intervention that halted this scourge."

Gold/Richter finally turned his face slightly, without really meeting Lance's gaze.

"What do you mean?"

Lance's voice lost some of its confidence. It slowed down.

'...They had prepared measures... that were more radical. More extreme. If we'd intervened directly, they wouldn't have hesitated to resort to them. It was only because it was you... that they adhered to certain rules of engagement.'

The words hung in the room without making things any easier. Gold/Richter did not smile. His fingers tightened briefly on the sheet, then relaxed.

"I don't feel any sense of honour in it, though."

Lance lowered his gaze for a moment.

"My precognition was accurate. If trainers like me had intervened too soon, they wouldn't have made an exception for any device." He paused. "I'm sorry I can't really share the burden."

Gold/Richter replied almost immediately, in a surprisingly clear voice:

"Yes."

Lance looked up, surprised. He had not anticipated that acceptance.

Gold/Richter continued, more slowly, as if he were having to sort through thoughts that were still too heavy.

"I would have lost... without your assurance. Your approach wasn't entirely wrong. Neither was mine. I had my strengths. But I was consumed by frustration. And by something else."

He paused. His throat seemed to tighten for a moment.

"Your words helped me pull myself together. They reminded me of... Misty. Red. And you."

At last, he really looked at Lance.

Lance, for his part, looked away slightly. A small, almost involuntary movement.

"...Fortunately, something I've done is still of use to young people..."

He said it without pride, without even a hint of satisfaction, as if it were a simple observation he dared not fully grasp.

Gold/Richter fell silent for a second, then asked, in a lower voice:

"Do you feel as though you've redeemed yourself...?"

The question clearly referred to Red. Lance knew it.

He did not answer straight away. When he spoke, his voice had grown hoarser.

"No. Only..." said Lance. "I was unable to save a child from the other world. Whereas I've managed to protect one from our own. It's a modest achievement. But... that's as far as I'll go."

He stood motionless for a few seconds, his gaze lost just beyond the bed.

Then, even more softly:

"I think Red would have wanted to help you with this dilemma."

After that, no one spoke.

The light continued to glide slowly across the wall. Gold/Richter turned his attention back to the same spot near the window. Lance made no attempt to resume the conversation. In the room, all that remained was the distant sound from the corridor and the undiminished weight of what had not been lightened.

End of scene

Scene – The Bill Settled

Municipal Hospital in Goldenrod City

Lance rose silently. He adjusted the collar of his jacket slightly, cast a final glance at Gold/Richter — a glance that demanded nothing — then made his way towards the door. The faint creak of the hinges accompanied his departure.

That was enough.

Gold/Richter's gaze, which until then had been fixed on the windowsill, slipped involuntarily towards the doorway. A figure stood there, set back a little, in the relative gloom of the threshold. For a very brief moment, time seemed to contract. Gold/Richter's eyes widened. At first he thought it was a mirage caused by fatigue, a figment of his still-overburdened mind.

Green.

The other man saw him. He did not smile, nor did he make any gesture. His face remained calm, almost neutral. But that brief glance alone seemed to be enough for him. He took half a step back, turned his back with perfect naturalness, and walked away down the corridor at a normal pace, neither slow nor hurried.

Gold/Richter stood motionless, his breathing slightly laboured.

In the corridor, Green passed a boy with red hair who was standing near the wall. He did not linger. A mere sidelong glance, the quick assessment of someone who assumes he is a close acquaintance, then he carried on. Silver, for his part, froze. A painful sense of deference pierced his chest. He lowered his eyes slightly, his shoulders a little too stiff, unable to think of anything to say.

The door to the room opened again.

A nurse entered, carrying dark clothes folded on her forearms. She placed them carefully at the foot of the bed.

'These are for you.'

Gold/Richter looked down. A tailcoat. A shirt. Trousers. The fabric, the cut, even the way the collar was finished... almost identical to the ones he'd lost. The size was spot on. He slowly ran his fingers over the fabric, as if to make sure it was real.

"Thank you. Who are they from...?"

The nurse smoothed out a fold in the sheet.

"The other gentleman who was outside. He was the one who brought you here."

Gold/Richter looked up. It took him a moment to process what she'd said. He scanned the room for a note, a message, anything. There was nothing. Just the clothes, and, tucked between the shirt and the tail, a bill folded in half.

He unfolded it.

The handwriting was neat. The language was not the one commonly used in Goldenrod. It was Swiss German — the same spelling, the same turns of phrase as on the orders he used to place in his home town. And right at the bottom, the signature, simple, without any flourishes:

Green.

Gold/Richter stared at those letters for a long time. He understood. But the exact nature of the gesture, its significance, what it did or did not authorise, still eluded him. He slowly closed the invoice and slipped it under his clothes.

BGM ‘Somewhere Safe’ 00:59–until the end.

When he looked back towards the door, another figure stood in the shadows of the doorway. Silver. The boy seemed to want to step forward, to show that he wasn’t detached, that he was there. But the movement remained unfinished. His hands hesitated at his sides. He was content simply to be seen, without pushing any further.

Gold/Richter held his gaze for a brief moment, too weak to open anything. Silver nodded faintly, then faded away in turn.

Further down the hospital corridors, Green continued on his way towards the exit. No unnecessary movements. No pauses. He crossed the ground-floor lobby without attracting any attention, passed through the glass doors, and disappeared into the still-bright light of late afternoon.

Behind him, the room had fallen silent once more.

End of scene

Scene – Reciprocal Retaliation Is Optional

Gold/Richter’s room, Goldenrod City Municipal Hospital

The late-afternoon light had dimmed slightly. It now streamed in at an angle through the window, casting a pale strip across the opposite wall that offered no warmth.

Kimono Girl Kuni stood slightly to one side, a good distance from the bed. Not directly opposite. As if she had been standing there for some time already, without needing to announce her presence. The folds of her kimono remained perfectly still. Her face bore a very faint smile, tinged with a melancholic, almost hesitant kindness.

Gold/Richter turned his head towards her.

The movement was slow. His gaze, still heavy with the weariness of the previous days, unwittingly took on a hint of unintentional hostility. He realised this immediately. He tried to correct his expression, to soften his features, to form at least the beginnings of a polite smile.

His lips tensed.

Then they relaxed.

He tried again. More conscientiously. The muscles in his face obeyed for a moment, then gave way once more, as if too heavy. A third attempt ended in the same way. His gaze drifted towards the sheet. He had the distinct impression that he was betraying the quiet generosity of the young woman sitting opposite him. That he was no longer even capable of doing the bare minimum required.

Kuni said nothing.

BGM 'EP01 S02 08:00–08:16'

She did not approach him either. Her smile, already there, deepened only slightly — not out of pity, but out of a discreet and awkward understanding. She had seen his efforts. She asked for none. Her presence remained a gift, with no expectation of anything in return.

Gold/Richter finally stopped trying so hard.

He gave up on the idea of giving anything back. He simply accepted that this kindness was there, even though he couldn't respond to it. And it was at that precise moment, when he was no longer seeking anything, that a very faint smile appeared on his face. Small. Almost as if he were surprised by it himself. Natural for the first time in days.

Kuni saw it.

She said nothing. She simply stood there, in the slanting light, whilst Gold/Richter's smile lingered for a moment longer, fragile and involuntary, before the room slipped back into its usual silence.

End of scene

Scene – The Sequel to the Wisdom of Ice

Gold/Richter's room, Goldenrod City Municipal Hospital

The room had grown greyer. The daylight was fading, offering little warmth. Gold/Richter had placed the laptop on his lap, sinking slightly into the pillows. The screen lit up after a few seconds of booting up.

Pryce's face appeared.

White hair, very light blue eyes, his hand resting near his chin. Behind him, one could make out a cold room, perhaps a window looking out onto the snow. The image wasn't perfect; a slight lag sometimes delayed the movements.

Gold/Richter spoke first, his voice still bearing the marks of his time in hospital.

"You were right, Mr Pryce... about what was really behind them."

BGM 'EP02 S01 15:30–16:06'

Pryce did not reply straight away. His eyes closed for a moment, as if to hold back an exclamation that was too clear. When he opened them again, his expression had become more pensive.

"May the gods protect you."

He paused, then added in a lower voice:

"I regret that my offer did not carry more weight."

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

"Yes. It didn't have much effect. But it opened up a first passage for me. The opponent was simply... too clear-headed."

He fell silent. His breathing grew a little shallower. Then, with visible effort:

"If that move embodied the wisdom of ice... forgive me for having executed it so poorly."

A very faint smile flitted across Pryce's face. Not one of amusement, but of understanding:

"The wisdom of ice goes far beyond a TM."

He lowered his eyes for a moment, then continued, more slowly, as if choosing each phrase with care.

BGM "EP02 S02 15:20–16:20"

"I know ice. Both the technique and its nature. But that's not the point.

What matters is surviving what it brings with it. Every year.

We have weathered more winters than we can count. Generation after generation. We can contain the snow. We cannot erase it. It returns. Just as the shadow returns after the light.

So we learn its nature. We grow stronger. We treat those we love as flesh-and-blood beings. And we pass it on.

Otherwise, that coldness eventually breaks you. That is why... you were able to weather the one that has returned this time."

Gold/Richter did not reply.

He stared at the screen, his face still heavy with fatigue, unable to formulate anything coherent. Pryce's words had settled within him, dense, abstract, and yet strangely tangible. He had no retort. Only that vague sensation that he had been handed something which might only take effect much later.

Pryce made no attempt to break the silence. He simply remained focused on the screen, waiting for the connection to end of its own accord.

End of scene

Scene – The fragile but precious bond

Gold/Richter's room, Municipal Hospital, Goldenrod City

The light had changed. It now streamed in lower through the window, a muted orange that no longer really warmed the walls. Shadows stretched across the floor of the room.

Eusine approached without haste. He stopped at a respectful distance from the bed, his gaze steady and attentive. Gold/Richter, for his part, looked up only out of the corner of his eye. Not out of indecency. The questions he was harbouring were simply the sort that promised little gentleness.

He spoke first, his voice still bearing the mark of his days in hospital.

'May I broach the sensitive subjects?'

Eusine tilted his head slightly. A tiny gesture was enough.

BGM 'Making Monsters' 00:00–00:44

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice:

“The spectre of the archaic world... it’s not just a bit of fun, is it?”

Eusine didn’t reply straight away:

“Have you seen it?”

“Behind Apollo.”

The silence that followed was longer. Eusine seemed to be coming to terms internally with what he had just heard. His eyes wandered for a moment towards the window, then returned.

Gold/Richter continued, almost in spite of himself:

“That was my question... during your lecture. The darkness that preceded the establishment of our tradition.”

Eusine waited a little longer before speaking.

“In the archives... the names vary. But the characteristics are consistent. A memory that people sought to eclipse. And a terror that has remained vivid.”

Gold/Richter nodded faintly.

“That follows ...”

He let a few seconds pass. Then, more slowly:

“If that is the source of our imprecation ... then, when I was fighting Murkrow and Houndoom... I was also fighting that spectre. Indirectly.”

Eusine looked at him for a long time.

“So your way of winning was not reprehensible. At least... not in the sense of who is the strongest, or the most insidious. If it is still after you, it is probably not for such trivialities.”

Gold/Richter closed his eyes briefly.

“Let us leave that topic for now. It is too gloomy.”

He paused, then steered the conversation in a different direction, as one might change the subject.

“To what extent... have you thrown yourself into the hunt for Suicune?”

Eusine’s expression changed. The solemn intensity softened slightly, giving way to something more deeply felt.

“From the very first time I saw it... its grace captivated me. It made me want to learn. That’s why I came to Johto.”

Gold/Richter looked at him askance.

“And was that motive merely a stepping stone...?”

Eusine smiled ever so slightly, without a trace of vanity.

BGM ‘Don’t Leave Me’ 01:27–end

"I sought the source of that fascination. It stemmed from a refined and benevolent culture. I haven't given up on that quest. But I've found fulfilment in other ways. Through stories. Through people. Finding joy in the journey itself seemed to me to be more fulfilling than owning the Pokémon."

He added, in a quieter voice:

"Its beauty, I believe, also stems from a sense of responsibility. I sometimes recognise the same trait... in Red. And in you."

Gold/Richter looked away for a moment.

"I sensed it in your speech."

"Didn't it bore you?"

"Not at all. I enjoyed it. And it's a surprise... that a stranger should know our stories so well. I really do enjoy your tales."

Eusine took no pride in these words. He simply accepted them.

Gold/Richter continued, with an awkwardness he himself could sense:

"Mr Eusine... you're a true hero."

Eusine shook his head gently.

"I take no credit for it."

"Forgive my choice of words. Apollo said that adults had sacrificed children to their own complacency. You, on the other hand, came to the children's aid when they were alone. Without being a combat trainer. By drawing on your intelligence. It was... gallant. Almost heroic in their eyes. This is no flattery."

He knew the words were still too heavy with meaning. Eusine read him clearly, neither dismissing them nor taking credit for them.

"I'm settling a debt with Red, for having protected Johto before you did."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze.

"Sorry I couldn't manage it on my own... or be as strong as him."

Eusine immediately rejected that line of thinking.

"Not that kind of self-effacement. Evil has evolved. In this day and age, no clear-headed person still believes we can defeat it alone."

He paused for a moment, then added:

"Red didn't just protect regions. He indirectly ensured that certain people can still exist as they are. In Kanto... I probably wouldn't have been able to remain myself without trauma, without discrimination. I'm grateful to Johto."

Gold/Richter raised his head slightly.

"Nevertheless... do you look down on Kanto? Your birthplace."

The question was asked with what appeared to be neutral curiosity. But its underlying tone was not quite so neutral.

Eusine did not reply straight away. His gaze grew distant, almost melancholic.

‘You should know that some questions... cannot be answered without difficulty. Even at my age.’

He could have said more. He chose not to. Not only out of caution, but also so as not to set an example to the younger ones of a prejudice formed too hastily.

Gold/Richter pressed the point, however, more gently:

“So you consider yourself more of a... resident of Johto?”

Eusine shook his head.

“Not that either. As my journey went on, I discovered something else. Even amongst people from the same country, who speak the same language... the divisions can run deep. Across generations. In terms of mindset. Through misunderstanding.

What still allows us to come together are more fragile things: culture, language, faith, a certain idea of what it means to be human.

It’s an imperfect connection. Fleeting. But precious. If we lose it... blood, nationality, ethnicity can never restore it. I’m content simply to contribute to it.”

He said this with an awkwardness unusual for him, as if the depth of what he was saying went beyond the words at his disposal.

Gold/Richter listened without interrupting. Then, more naturally, almost in spite of his tiredness:

‘But I’m delighted that you’re in Johto.’

The sentence came out effortlessly, without calculation. Eusine clearly sensed its sincerity. He turned his face slightly towards the window, where the last glimmer of twilight still lingered, faint and cold.

End of scene

Scene – The Finitude of Elevated Lucidity

Gold/Richter’s room, Municipal Hospital in Goldenrod City

Twilight light streamed in low, without warmth. It cast a grey strip across the opposite wall, which was gradually fading.

Gold/Richter’s eyes were open, but he was no longer looking at the room. Fragments came flooding back to him in waves: the all-too-precise flapping of Murkrow’s wings, the smell of sulphur and burnt fur, the way Houndoom had moved through the mist as if it had never wavered. The savagery hadn’t been left behind. It had left a mark. A vibration beneath the skin. A fear of his own hands.

On the windowsill, Fearow sat far too still. Scyther would occasionally scratch the floor with a paw, for no reason. Alakazam kept its eyes half-closed, focused on something he wasn’t showing. Ampharos, near the bed, had the light from its tail shining lower than usual. They weren’t infected. They were worried.

Chris/Maria was already there. Sitting, leaning forward slightly, her eyes heavy. She'd been watching him for a while. On the table, several cards and small packets lay in a row, still unopened.

BGM 'You've Seen the Devil'

She spoke first, in a flat tone.

'This is from Mike, Bryan and Krise. They knew you weren't in any state to speak.'

Gold/Richter barely turned his head.

'That's kind...'

The words came out without any real politeness. More out of guilt than by design.

Chris/Maria regarded him for a little longer.

"You've changed. Even your Pokémon can see it."

He didn't reply. His gaze drifted down to his own forearms, resting on the sheet. The hospital gown revealed the outline of the muscles in his chest – lean, functional, without a hint of ostentation. She couldn't help but notice it. She didn't dwell on it.

"I never imagined... that you could train to such an extent and still find yourself so powerless."

"I trained out of a sense of duty. For practical purposes."

She pressed the point, speaking more quietly:

"Did you ever think... of using it to start something new?"

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

"It's not about purism. Muscle strength doesn't solve anything. It demands even more discipline. So as not to... slip. That's also why I wear this outfit."

A silence.

"Haven't you even once thought... about using it to pick up where you left off?" she said.

He took a while to reply.

"Yes. But I'd have been afraid. That she'd be there, but her heart would be elsewhere. Even if I'd managed to keep her. I'm too sensitive about that. I dress like this too, so as not to... bring back memories."

Chris/Maria looked down for a moment.

"Or perhaps... that girl doesn't matter quite so much anymore."

Gold/Richter found it harder to speak.

"I'd told myself that after I left... she'd become less mature. That it would make my regret easier to bear. But she's blossomed. Even if it took effort. I don't even know anymore... whether I've fallen in love again. Or whether it's even worse."

"Or you never stopped."

He did not reply straight away. His jaw clenched.

"I'd like to say it. I don't dare."

Chris/Maria stared out of the window for a moment.

"It's strange... when someone close to you changes so much that you can hardly recognise them. I'd hoped there'd be at least a trace left."

"You're right. I don't even know how she manages not to hold it against me too much."

She continued, more curtly:

"It's not easy. In the Radio Tower... I had to resort to some dubious methods. So I understood a bit better what was happening to you more often."

Gold/Richter closed his eyes briefly.

"Yes. I used a... brutal method. To survive.

The consequences are clear. I'm no longer sure if I'm still myself. Or if I'm already... something else."

Chris/Maria looked at him.

"You have shown, though, that Pokédex holders... are not like that."

"As I was slipping into it... I could see more clearly what stemmed from that bestiality. And what didn't."

"There you go again with the self-reproach."

"No. I realised that certain things about me... weren't set in stone. That they could slip away."

She fell silent. The remark had affected her more than she'd expected.

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa'

Gold/Richter continued, his voice lower, almost broken:

"I distanced myself from her... to spare her what Misty went through with Red. I thought I was hurting her the most. It was me."

Chris/Maria frowned slightly, not quite understanding yet.

"I was caught up in a simple idea," he said. "Even the love between Misty and Red doesn't stop the most insidious evil. So love would be... dispensable. I cut myself off from it. And then I realised just how incomplete I'd become."

Tears welled up, clear and distinct. He made almost no attempt to hold them back:

"Don't look. Please. I don't want this to force you to forgive me."

Chris/Maria looked away, but not completely; she kept her gaze at just the right angle to see.

Gold/Richter spoke more quickly, as if something were giving way:

"Faced with someone so clear-sighted... I was transparent. He hardly needed to fight me. Just to read me. Even a softening ... was enough to reduce me to this state, to strip me of my courage. Despite the resources at my disposal. A humiliation. At the hands of a demon. Without him even really trying."

The tears flowed more freely.

"The others helped me. But without her... I would have lost. Even with the injustice I'd inflicted on her."

He paused, breathless.

"Before, I used to wonder if I'd left her out of selfishness. Not because the pain would have been too much for her... but for me. Now I'm wondering something else. If I'd known how much I needed... that... would I have made the same choice? Would I have stayed just to fill the void? I no longer know if I was being generous. Or just... playing it safe."

Chris/Maria looked up. Her voice came out harsher, almost accusatory, before she could stop it.

"You don't know yourself well enough. Some people..."

She paused. Then continued, without softening her tone:

"Even if you'd known. You'd have pretended. That's just the way you are. And in that case... you'd have worn yourself out even more. It might even have cost you your life."

Tears welled up in her eyes too. She didn't wipe them away.

"Don't speak as though your life meant nothing to anyone," she said. "As if we'd manage just fine without you."

Gold/Richter looked at her, his eyes wide open, as if he were receiving something he'd carefully avoided.

His voice trembled.

"Being the strongest... doesn't fix everything," he said. "So I don't want to be anymore. I just wanted... for no one to get hurt. For no one to be sacrificed. I failed. Again."

Chris/Maria shook her head, her tears now more visible.

"Being the strongest doesn't solve everything. But if you refuse even to be the strongest... You're imperfect. That's exactly where you fall short. You get stuck."

He stared at her, struck by her words. The sentence was simple. It should have been obvious. It hadn't been.

Chris/Maria continued, her voice lower, almost without strength:

"So stop. Accept your limits. Your imperfection has a right to exist.

I didn't know... that you had to bear so much pain just to stay close to someone. So... should I let you go?"

Gold/Richter closed his eyes. The tears came harder, uncontrollably.

"No... I don't want to leave anymore. It's humiliating. But I can't manage it without this."

He could hardly bring himself to look her in the face.

Chris/Maria stood motionless for a long moment. Tears were still streaming down the sides of her face. She didn't hide them.

"Well then... you're welcome to stay. Even if it is humiliating."

She did not come closer. She did not kiss him. She simply let him cry, in the room that had grown almost dark, whilst outside the twilight was fading away.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 14,000 words · 38 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 95 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

contract · plastered · said Chris/Maria · sketched · cursive · trivialities · crop unique.
Durations excluding titles. Notes moved here. P1: sequel → aftermath; Soil → Ground;
Inglorious Chivalry → Gallantry Without Glory; Unforeseen Victory → Victory Beyond
Calculation; bounty → premium; Fearow/Dewgong pronouns → it/its; reverence (not merely respect).

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Encore / Glare tariff. Lamento = external. Traces = address. Author filled. Title: The Demon's Softening. Two Lances distinguished. Softening locked to the closing admission.

Open for what follows

Giovanni · Coyote · “her” · Eusine without an answer on Kanto.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.

